

“Ideological Guerrilla” at the University of Ottawa



Photo: RobCA, public domain Since Saturday, the 34 signatories of the letter to support Verushka Lieutenant-Duval have been the victims of a virulent campaign of cyberbullying.

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(This is the Google-translation English version of the French original.)

<https://www.ledevoir.com/societe/588195/mot-qui-commence-par-n-guerilla-ideologique-a-l-universite-d-ottawa?fbclid=IwAR3kQvay29iSaTU9g-q2Pm44nY1JudU1vZDCId1zA0bKeGOlgkq6dbOBxUE>

Some have received hundreds of tweets calling for their “rehabilitation”. Others feared that their offices would be ransacked. Many admit to being scared, to the point where a teacher has even asked his children to stay with their other parent while the storm passes.

Since Saturday, the 34 signatories of the letter aiming to support Verushka Lieutenant-Duval - abandoned, according to their statements, by the management of the University of Ottawa for having used "the word beginning with an n" in a university teaching context - are victims of a virulent campaign of cyberbullying.

The ball was launched on Saturday with a tweet stipulating that the teachers, in their letter, "supported the use of the N word in class", adding "we will cyberbully them".

In the process, Lucie Hotte, full professor in the French department of the University of Ottawa, said to have received hundreds of tweets describing her as racist, calling for her dismissal by the university and asking for her "re-education".

"This is not at all what we say in the letter," she indignantly. We expected people to disagree with us, but no one expected our offices to be vandalized, our jobs to be lost for defending a young lecturer unjustly accused and which is not defended by its institution and that we call for our re-education by falling into the Maoist ideology. "

Maxime Prévost, director of the French department at the University of Ottawa, is equally stunned. "We don't feel very safe, even at home, since the address of Verushka Lieutenant-Duval has been posted on social networks," he worries.

The tone is very inflamed and follows a logic of hatred and intimidation, he is alarmed. "We feel that it is going completely wrong. And we feel that we have become an object of hatred. For the first time in my life, I'm glad we're in confinement. "

Marc-François Bernier, professor of journalism in the communications department at the University of Ottawa, said he was just as relieved to be far from campus. "We work remotely, which protects us a bit. If we were in a normal context on campus, I would be more on the lookout," he emphasizes.

The fear of seeing their personal addresses disseminated, of being physically challenged or of seeing students causing mayhem in their classes is very present for some.

" People are scared. Not to the point of hiding somewhere, but we are careful. It would be ill-advised not to pay attention. We can see what is happening elsewhere, "slips Lucie Hotte, referring to the assassination of a teacher in France last week.

Professors say they have been assured that more supervision will be carried out near their desks. But what does the University of Ottawa intend to do to calm the situation? How does it plan to support faculty members targeted by the intimidation campaign and what measures will be taken against students making intimidating comments? The institution did not answer our questions on Tuesday. The Association of Professors of the University of Ottawa, the union representing the faculty, also did not respond to our interview request.

At the Ottawa police, Constable Amy Gagnon indicates that no investigation has been launched for the moment since no complaint has been received. "However, if a

complaint is made online or through our call center, it can take 24 to 48 hours before it is assigned to our criminal investigation unit," she explains.

For Marie-Hélène Giroux, criminal lawyer, it is clear that the behaviors observed can constitute criminal offenses, relating to criminal harassment, uttering threats or even incitement to commit an offense. "These are offenses which are taken seriously by the police authorities and by the legislator", she underlines. M^e Giroux also notes that the codes of conduct of educational institutions generally provide for penalties up to and including dismissal for this type of behavior.

In the letter published on Saturday, the 34 professors express their disagreement with the treatment of Verushka Lieutenant-Duval - who used the word derogatory to explain a theoretical concept, according to an account of the incident published in *La Presse* .

The group of professors, mostly white and French-speaking, wrote: "It is important that university administrations, while participating in the discovery and abolition of all forms of systemic racism, ensure that the transmission of knowledge and development are protected. of critical thinking and academic freedom. "

Rector Jacques Frémont's statement, released Monday, disappointed many of them. "Members of dominant groups simply do not have the legitimacy to decide what constitutes microaggression," he responded.

For Maxime Prévost, it is nothing less than a cultural war that is being played out on the University of Ottawa campus. "We are living a very important moment which will be important for all universities. This is a fundamental case that will set a precedent. "

Marc-François Bernier describes the movement as an "ideological guerrilla". "I am very disappointed [with the university's reaction]. Fundamental principles are dropped to please customers. "

Joël Beddows, professor of theater at the University of Ottawa, also signatory of the letter, prefers for his part to refocus the debate by recalling that knowledge is power. "It sure can hurt [to use certain words]. Myself, as a gay man who has been the victim of harassment, abuse, physical violence, when I hear the words fag or fag, it hurts me. But I'm going to use them in a context where I think it can advance the cause of social justice. "

"Right now there is too much noise. We're wasting time. "

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